PRD: Targeting RBC Direct Investing Pain-Points

Unified Accounts, Portfolio Insights & Auto-Invest

Kelly Kim | April 4, 2026

Target User

Primary user: the mobile-first user. RBC DI clients aged roughly 25–40, employed full-time, contributing to their TFSA or RRSP on a regular cadence. They typically hold 5–15 positions weighted toward broad-market ETFs with a small individual-stock satellite. They open the app from mobile almost exclusively and treat investing as a recurring habit, not an active pursuit.

The job they're trying to do: build long-term wealth on a consistent cadence with minimal ongoing effort.

What they fire to hire alternatives: when RBC's tooling slows them down, they open more user-friendly applications — such as Wealthsimple. Gradually, RBC keeps the deposit relationship and loses the investing one — and over time, often the deposit relationship too.

Why this is important to address: highest churn risk segment within DI today, and the highest lifetime-value cohort over a 10-year horizon given long compounding tails.

Current State

- Users can switch between banking and investing profiles, but no single net-worth view exists
- Mobile shows a flat holdings list with no allocation chart. The desktop Trading Dashboard has a Portfolio Analyzer (asset-class, sector, regional breakdowns) that should be brought to iOS
- Supports stocks, options, mutual funds, and ETFs with free real-time streaming quotes
- No recurring or automated investments. Every trade requires a manual order

Problem

These are the three pain points

1. **Moving idle cash to investments takes too many steps.** When the user's paycheck lands, he or she would want to push a portion into investments in under a minute. RBC forces them to switch between banking and investing tabs, check balances on two different screens, and do mental math on how much is "extra." This is a friction point for investing.
2. **They can't see allocation drift from mobile.** When the user wants a quick check before adding to a position, they expect a visual breakdown on their phone. RBC mobile shows a flat holdings list with no chart. The desktop Portfolio Analyzer exists but is effectively invisible to a mobile-first user.
3. **Investing on a schedule requires the user to invest manually for each order.** When the user wants to dollar-cost average — the strategy almost every personal-finance source recommends — they must remember to log in and place each order manually. Inconsistency is the failure mode. WealthSimple or Questrade eliminates this with auto-invest into any security on a schedule. RBC requires the user to do the work each time.

Evidence

Market — external

- Wealthsimple offers **recurring auto-buys for any stock or ETF** on weekly, bi-weekly, or monthly schedules — the exact gap RBC DI has today.
- In the iOS App Store Canada Finance category, **Wealthsimple ranks #1; RBC Mobile ranks #4**. On Google Play, Wealthsimple Invest carries a 4.4-star rating versus RBC Mobile's 2.2 stars.
- Statistics Canada's Survey of Financial Security 2023 (released Oct 29, 2024) shows the **under-35 cohort had the largest gain in real median net worth of any age group** from 2019 to 2023, up 179% to $159,100. The cohort has accumulating capital that's actively being deployed into self-directed brokerage accounts — the question is whose.
- A Wealthsimple-commissioned study of 1,000 Canadian clients aged 25–45 with $50K+ in investable assets reports **92% feel confident managing their own investments** and 69% report above-average risk tolerance — the demographic profile most likely to move their investing relationship away from a bank brokerage.

User research — qualitative, structured

- 10–15 in-depth interviews with mobile-first DI clients in the 25–40 segment, sampled to include both retained clients and those who reduced activity in the past 6 months. Focus on contribution and rebalance journeys.
- Targeted survey to DI clients with declining trade volume, asking where their contributions are going and why.
- Mobile usability study on the current contribution flow to baseline time-to-completion before any changes ship.

Proposed Solution

> *Recommended sequencing: Portfolio Allocation first (lowest effort, leverages existing quote data), then Unified Dashboard (data access exists, mainly a UI build), then Auto-Invest last (requires new backend + compliance review).*

1. Portfolio Allocation Breakdown

- Pie chart showing % allocation by holding, inspired by Bloom's approach
- Tap any slice for details: book cost, gain/loss, recent price movement
- Secondary grouping by asset class or sector for a higher-level view

2. Unified Account Dashboard

- Single screen showing total net worth across all RBC accounts (chequing, savings, TFSA, RRSP, margin, etc.)
- Tap any account for details or to initiate a transfer
- Front-end restructuring. The app already has both banking and investing data

3. Auto-Invest

- Recurring buy orders for any stock or ETF, across all DI account types

— Users set frequency (weekly/monthly), dollar amount, and funding account
— Orders execute during market hours. Pause, modify, or cancel anytime

Risks

Risk	Impact	Mitigation
Building scheduled order execution from scratch	High	Start with an ETFs-only beta to limit complexity
Market orders during volatile periods could mean poor fills	Med	Add disclaimers during setup; explore limit orders for V2
Regulatory review could delay the auto-invest launch	Med	Bring compliance in during sprint 1
Pie chart gets cluttered with 15+ holdings	Med	Group positions under 3% into an “Other” slice

Dependencies

— **Banking data access** — already exists. The app has it today
— **Market data** — real-time streaming quotes are already free for all DI clients
— **Scheduled order execution** — this is the main build. Doesn’t exist yet
— **Compliance review** — why is there different tab for personal banking and direct investing? There would be a reason here

The critical path is the auto-invest backend and compliance review. The other two features can move independently.

Success Criteria

Metric	Target	Reasoning	Timeframe
Auto-invest enrollment	15-20% of eligible users	Benchmarked against Wealthsimple’s early adoption rates in Canada	3 months
Monthly active investors	+10%	Auto-invest should reduce friction for repeat trades	6 months
Portfolio breakdown taps	>1 per session	If users tap in regularly, the feature is part of their workflow	3 months

Open Questions

1. Is a combined net-worth view actually valuable to the user, or is the existing tab-switching good enough? *Plan: 5-8 user interviews with a prototype*
2. Should auto-invest launch for all securities or start with ETFs only? *Plan: survey existing DI users on what they'd want to automate*
3. Do users prefer a visual pie chart, or would something closer to the desktop Portfolio Analyzer format work better on mobile? *Plan: A/B prototype test*
4. Are we right that the mobile-first user is the highest-leverage user, or is the older consolidator a comparable opportunity? *Plan: cohort sizing + LTV modelling before scoping V2*